

100 YEAR HISTORY WALK – WATER SCHEME AND TANK



Since the towns beginnings in 1876 the lack of permanent water and storage was an issue that had been continually debated. When the settlers arrived, they found the government had sunk two wells in the district. The “Nelia Well” on Mr H. Pomery’s property three miles west, and the “Jimmy’s Well” on Mr McInerney’s property, three miles to the east had been previously sunk on pastoral runs.

Mr Rohde enlisted help from Koch Brothers to sink a well on his property in 1876 and the following year one was sunk on Koch’s property.

On Tuesday 15th February 1881 a meeting was held at the Petersburg Hotel in regard to the “wants of the district.” It was decided to petition the government to establish a local court and asked them to assist in securing an adequate water supply for the town.

Due to the dry summer of 1881/1882 water carting for domestic and farming use from the public wells in the district was needed and farmers were forced to drive stock to water. The railway dam built in the town held little to no water and all other dams were dry.

In December 1885 Koch Brothers adopted a system for supplying a portion of the community. They erected a windmill on their well in the township which pumped water into two galvanised tanks at an elevation of about 10 feet. From these tanks pipes were laid and water was supplied to about a dozen families at a modest charge.

When it did rain there was no provision for water storage and other than fill domestic tanks most of the water soon dried up.

Water carting was again necessary in 1891 and as the population grew so did the urgency for a permanent water supply.

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At a meeting on Friday 22nd April 1892 to discuss the subject of a permanent water supply, several schemes were suggested, the most popular being the sources of water from the Nelia Well. A committee was appointed and correspondence was sent to the government. They were advised by the members for the district that when the government were arranging for a supply for railway purposes would also consider the question of a supply for the town.

The Commissioner of Public Works was then waited upon with reference to an additional water supply. A petition signed by 223 residents was presented, which stated that there was a population of 2,000 in the district, and they were wholly dependent on wells and tanks for their supply. The water in many of these wells is totally unfit for drinking purposes, and owing to the uncertain rainfall the tanks were practically dry for months at a time. Owing in a great measure to the quality and scarcity of water many cases of typhoid and similar diseases had occurred and were still occurring. Several of the deputationists spoke strongly in support of the requisition, impressing upon the Government the necessity of carrying on the work without delay. Mr. W. HEATHERSAY stated that the rainfall from January 1 to July 30 had only been 2.660. With water at 2s. 6d. per 200 gallons it was impossible for the laboring classes to carry on gardening work on their

blocks. If the work was pushed on with at once a number of unemployed could obtain work. There was a natural reservoir and a well close to the township that could be used. The Commissioner replied that if the residents of Petersburg guaranteed a certain sum to maintain the works something might be done in the matter, but nevertheless he would obtain a report from the Engineer-in-Chief as to the most suitable scheme. He had been informed by Mr. Moncrieff that a good supply could be obtained both for railway and township purposes about 11 miles from Petersburg, but the cost of reticulation from that place would be exceedingly heavy. Mr. GILES considered it was hard that the residents should have to give a guarantee to bring rain water 11 miles for the railway when good well water could be obtained nearer to the township and reticulated at a small cost. Mr. HANDYSIDE promised to report the matter to his colleagues.

Express and Telegraph
Thursday 14 July 1892

A party of councillors and Mr Stewart, the engineer in charge of the selection of a site for a reservoir, visited a site for inspection on Thursday 20th April 1893. The reservoir which was to be for railway and town usage was to be about a mile almost due south of the Minvalara Dam, in the Hundred of Morgan and about twelve miles northeast of Petersburg. Mr Stewart stated that after examining the whole of the country within 12 miles of Petersburg, it appeared that the site now selected was the best suited for a water supply to Petersburg. The catchment area included about six square miles of country and the water was calculated to flow freely into the reservoir valley. The site was about seventy feet above the height of the town of Petersburg and therefore the water should gravitate from the supply to the town, and a pumping station and supply reservoir would be unnecessary.

The site was visited several weeks later by the Engineer-in-Chief (Mr A.B. Moncrieff) and he expressed to the mayor that he was well pleased with the site he had inspected and although no final decision had been made, he expected to have everything complete and the plans and details ready to be submitted to the government in about 3 weeks. He wished the local authorities to let him know in which streets they would like the mains laid down.

Another meeting was held to consider a permanent water supply to the town on Wednesday 21st February 1894 as the promised supply by the railways for the town and their usage had fallen through.

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It wasn't until August 1903 that a move was made by the government to establish a water supply in Petersburg. Several sites were visited with the purpose of testing for the suitability of establishing a reservoir. Mr Crowley's farm about 2 miles from the township was the first site visited, followed by Paradise Alley, then the artesian bore at the Morgan Well on the Dawson Road, constructed years ago by Mr D. McKeough, Mr Donaldsons west of the town, the Gumbowie Ranges near Thyer's Corner, and the racecourse.

In 1910 Petersburg was visited by C.A. Bayer and Mr Hicks (government hydraulic engineers) and they and the mayor Mr W. Butterworth visited the various sites suggested for the construction of a reservoir. They concluded that a reservoir would not be suitable and that the best source of water for the town would come from a well.

In June 1914 Mr Pink had success with the sinking of a well in Main Street and the council were approached by Mr Alexander (of the South Australian Well Drilling Company) and Mr Pink in reference to a council well. A well was sunk near the Power Station with good results.

The Council had been looking at an underground supply and in 1918 the Government sent an expert to test the Council well in the town. Tests were run and they showed that there was an ample supply of water and could be raised at a low cost. The water was tasted and it was exceptionally good. The water was then analysed and it was a "Knock-out blow" to find that it was saline, and not suitable for everyday use.

PETERBOROUGH WATER SCHEME.

For over 30 years leading citizens of Peterborough have been agitating for a water supply, but there seems to be some insurmountable obstacle in the way, that up to the present has not been removed. Several suitable schemes, to the lay mind, have been brought forward from time to time, but always the same result. During the past few years the Council, at the instigation of Cr. Dickson, have been devoting their attention to an underground supply, and samples of water from numerous wells were tested and found satisfactory, and a promise made to place an amount on the Estimates for the work. This year the Government sent an expert to try the Corporation well, and after many severe tests it was found that there was an ample supply for all purposes, and that it could be raised at a very low cost. So satisfactory were the tests that the Council, the expert, and others interested felt confident the question was settled, and that in due course the long sought for water scheme would be an accomplished fact. Consequently the following paragraph in the daily press last week came as a great surprise to all concerned:—

"The proposal that the people of Peterborough should be provided with a water supply from a well in the centre of the town, from which it should be pumped into a distributing tank or reservoir, received a knock-out blow on Tuesday at a meeting of the Royal Commission on Water Supply. Correspondence was received from the Director of Chemistry (Dr. Hargreaves), who had made an analysis of the water, and the Government Geologist (Mr. K. Ward), both of whom supported the view previously expressed by the Hydraulic Engineer (Mr. C. A. Bayer), that the water was not pure enough to warrant the expenditure that would be involved. There is abundance of water in the well, but it is saline and otherwise objectionable, although in case of a shortage it might be used. The well is subject to contamination from the drainage from the sanitary depot, the sale yards, and the cemetery, all of which are within the catchment area. Dr. Hargreaves stated that he found a high percentage of nitrates in the water, which pointed

to serious contamination from sources similar to those mentioned. The reports were so strongly adverse that the Commission regarded the well as condemned from the point of view of a general supply for domestic use, and the secretary was instructed to inform the local municipal council accordingly.

This is, as stated, a knock-out blow, especially as the water was considered by those who tasted it, to be exceptionally good. It is inconceivable that a surface depot a mile away should contaminate an underground supply, and there surely must be some other explanation of the mysterious impurity of the water. We expect the Corporation will be enquiring further into the matter, and we trust that some better result will be achieved. Should this scheme be turned down it is not likely that a better one will be forthcoming. That one of the most important centres in the State should be without a water supply does not reflect credit upon the State.

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This was a disappointment for the Council and the town and they felt that the report should not have been published in the press. It created a scare amongst the citizens who had been relying on wells for their water supply. Members of the Council were “dumbfounded” when they read the report and considered that they had been treated in an indiscreet manner and that it was an unwarranted de-framing of the town. The analysis was restudied and the water was declared fit to drink.

In 1924 a scheme to pump water from the Corporation Well by electric motor to an elevated tank and then pumped back to the town was considered.

In 1925 the residents of Peterborough finally gave permission by way of a petition for the go ahead of the scheme.

Testing in April 1926 saw a satisfactory result with the well pumped for 72 continuous hours. During that period 3,960 gallons per hour was pumped and a further test a few days later was also successful. The Commissioner of Public Works informed the council that his department would take over the running of the powerhouse well and that the water would be filtered with the use of a mechanical filtration plant.

The outline of Government conditions for construction of scheme is contained in the following letter, received 13/7/23.—“Adverting to previous correspondence on the above subject, I am directed by the Hon. Commissioner of Public Works to inform you that the Hydraulic Engineer has prepared an estimate of cost for supplying water to Peterborough to be pumped from the Corporation well by electric power to be supplied by the Corporation at the prices quoted by it in the letter of 12th April last.

“The estimated cost of the works, including elevated tank, reticulation mains, alterations to well, electric pump, etc., is £20,000. The revenue to accrue at the ordinary township scale of rating would amount to £1,390. Allowing £650 for the cost of maintenance and the pumping of the water, the net revenue of £740 would represent 3.7 per cent. on the estimated cost.

*Times and Northern Advertiser
Friday 31 October 1924*



*Pump on well at back of Power station - 1926
Photo – Peterborough Library History Room*

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In the assembly on Wednesday 24th November 1926, the Commissioner of Public Works announced that the Government had approved the purchase of the corporation well and the reserve on which it was situated, and £10,000 had been placed in the Loan Estimates for the Peterborough Water Scheme.

The scheme commenced in February 1927, with to government purchasing the site next to the power station which became known as the Engineering and Water Supply depot. Most houses in the town had their own supply of rainwater for human consumption and the water was mainly used for gardens and washing.

WATER SUPPLY.

COMMISSIONER OF PUBLIC
WORKS VISITS PETERBOROUGH.

SCHEME TO BE STARTED
IMMEDIATELY.

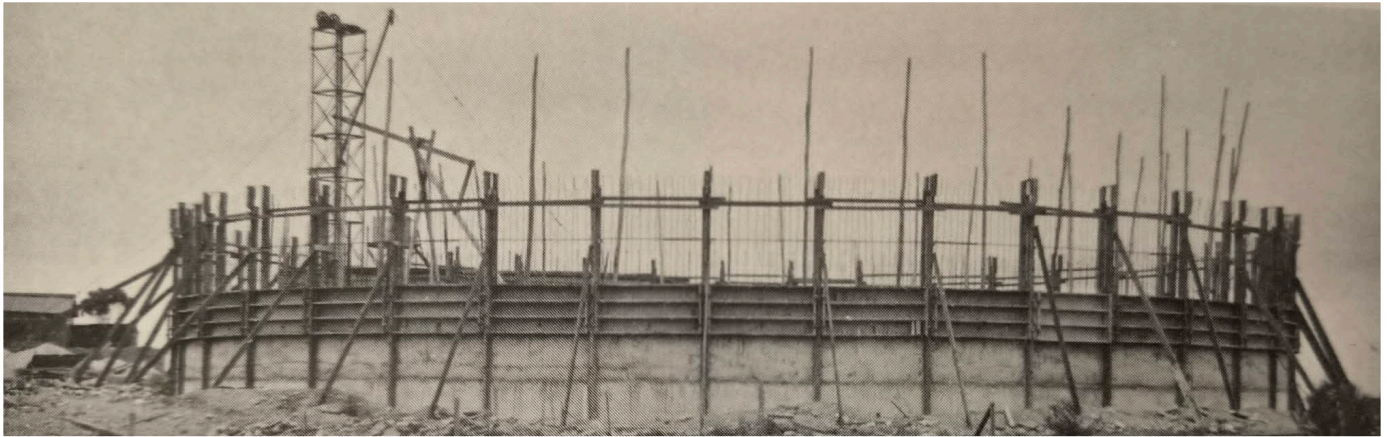
The Commissioner of Public Works (Mr. J. McInnes), accompanied by the Hydraulic Engineer (Mr. H. E. Bellamy), and the northern district engineer (Mr. A. J. Green), arrived at Peterborough on Tuesday afternoon from Clare. The party visited Hallett and Lerowie, and made enquiries regarding the provision of water for those towns. A site for the proposed reservoir known as German Gully, about a mile from Hallett was viewed. On the arrival at Peterborough they were met by Mr. McHugh, a Member for the district, and the mayor and councillors. They inspected the power house, the source of the water supply, and the land acquired by the Government in connection with the scheme. They also inspected the site for the storage tank, about a mile north of the town, over a hundred feet above the hospital, the highest point in the town. The party was favorably impressed and the Hydraulic Engineer was strongly of the opinion that the most adequate supply of good drinking water when filtered would be available. The party were met by the mayor and council in the chamber at night. The mayor (Mr. E. Hoile) extended a hearty welcome on behalf of the citizens, and hoped for good news of the water scheme. Mr. S. McHugh, M.P., endorsed the welcome.

The Minister said it was not the first time he had visited Peterborough, but it was his first official visit, as Commissioner of Public Works, which was essentially connected with water schemes for the country settlers. He was putting practically all his time enquiring into the water question. Boiled down it was purely a question of money. Not only had they to secure the money on the Estimates, but had to be extremely careful in spending it. They had a definite policy in water schemes, and although they could not expect in return an amount of revenue anything like the interest they had to pay, they did not consider it extravagance in any way. The Peterborough scheme had been under consideration for a long time. He had already given Mr. Bellamy instructions to go ahead with it immediately, and on his return would put his instructions in writing, and the work would begin forthwith. (Applause.) The sum of £10,000 was already on the estimates, and if he was in office for another term to deal with the question he would see that sufficient money was on the Estimates to complete the work of reticulation without any break. Authority had been given to purchase land. Immediately Mr. Bellamy could undertake the work he would do so departmentally, as he was a strong believer in this system. He proposed giving preference to the local labor available, and if there was not sufficient it would be secured from other quarters to carry out the work with economical speed. He hoped nothing would intervene to delay the work, and trusted the result of the visit would be so satisfactory that most of the town would have water for the next summer, and be made much happier and contented.

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After many delays and mishaps by August 1927 the motor had been erected at the powerhouse well and water had been pumped to the site of the water tank.

Building of the storage tank at the top of Government Road commenced on 23 August 1927 after the instillation of the motor at the well site. A small gang of men had been engaged to lay the pipe main along Victoria Street and had progressed as far as Jervois Street and was almost completed.



*Water storage tank under construction - 1927
Photo – Peterborough Library History Room*

At a council meeting on Monday 5th March 1928, Mr Green, the Waterworks Engineer informed the meeting that the tank was almost complete and could hold 10 feet of water at present.

Arrangements had been made to supply electric current to the tank along Government Road. This also meant that about 20 houses could be served from the same line. The Council erected the line at a cost of 30/- per pole for the government. Mr Green also advised the council that the water would be supplied to the Town Hall free of charge for fire purposes only.

The tank could hold half a million gallons of water and at last the town had a good supply of water with good pressure of 90 bs to the square inch.

With a plentiful supply of water, the show committee was finally able to improve the showgrounds and there was a call to establish a bowling green as previous attempts had failed due to the lack of water. Although the town now had water on supply, homes were equipped with rain water tanks and most people relied on tank water to drink and cook in.

The Fire Brigade Board inspected Peterborough and were satisfied that an auxiliary fire brigade could be formed as soon as the council forwarded the necessary application forms. The council would need to provide a fire station, at an estimated cost of £850, which the board would pay a rental of 8 per cent per annum.

There were concerns raised by the Water Works department in January 1930 that due to the severe strain of continual pumping for 18 hours a day during the past 18 months, along with the continued dry seasons, the supply was in danger.

The government announced water restrictions at Peterborough as there were too many consumers for the water available and pumping was reduced. The daily supply was cut from 240,000 gallons to 70,000 gallons, and they appealed to residents to cease garden watering and to exercise general care when using water.

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The scheme that was put into operation in 1928 was designed for 250 houses but by December 1930 there were over 500 connected to the scheme. Residents were paying water rates even though the water was not available to water lawns and flower gardens.

A new sanitary system was suggested in August 1932, which would require about 28,000 gallons of water per day. The conversion from pan to deep drainage system was unfortunately not able to be recommended as the water scheme could not handle the extra need for water.

The water shortage was again discussed at length at a February council meeting, and it was resolved to approach the government on the question of supplementing the scheme. By May the members of the district were to be approached to ascertain the result of the communication regarding the inadequate water supply in Peterborough. The government purchased two wells in section 209 from Mr Price and Mr Lloyd to supplement the water supply, although this didn't seem to help matters.

BY 1938 the water situation had not been resolved and residents and council were still not able to water their gardens. The council wrote to the Engineering and water supply for permission to use sprinklers on the lawns in the Main Street. It was suggested that the council take over the water scheme from the government.

Matter of supply of current to Water Works was discussed and it was suggested that in event of an adverse reply being received, a protest meeting of ratepayers and citizens be held and as an alternative the taking over of the whole scheme at Peterborough by the Corporation, as had been suggested.— Matter held over in accordance with E.S. committee's recommendation.

*Times and Northern Advertiser
Friday 25 February 1938*

The Business Men's Progress Society had been pushing for water to be supplied from the Murray River. The matter was brought before the Public Works Standing Committee in May 1939. The town council were in favour, but the district councillors felt that landowners could not afford the rate that would be imposed under the scheme.

Murray — Whyalla Water Scheme.

Extention to Peterborough and Terowie Sought.

Conflicting evidence was tendered at Peterborough on Wednesday afternoon. Whereas, representatives of the Peterborough Corporation strongly stressed the need for a supply from the contemplated Morgan-Whyalla trunk main, the District Council witnesses opposed the introduction of Murray water to the district, because of the additional burden ratepayers would have to bear.

*Times and Northern Advertiser
Friday 12 May 1939*

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Continued dry conditions in 1940 saw most residents Peterborough out of rainwater and forced to drink and cook in the town water supply, which was considered unfit for human consumption by many people. The local board of health suggested that the council contact the government with an endeavour to improve the quality of the water now that it was being used in place of rainwater. A sample was forwarded to the central board of health to ascertain whether the water was suitable for drinking purposes. It was sent to the Government Department of Chemistry and a detailed analysis found increased salt, but a decreased nitrate content from a previous analysis in 1938. The water was found to be organically sound.

A committee was formed in 1945 to stand behind the proposition to improve the present water supply and have the Murray River brought to Peterborough.

MURRAY WATER FOR PETERBOROUGH

MOVE MADE TO ESTABLISH CLAIM FOR ADEQUATE SUPPLY

RESOLUTION TO STAND BEHIND PROJECT

As everybody knows, Mr M. R. O'Halloran, our member for this district, is vitally interested and concerned about all matters affecting the residents of his electorate. Last week Mr O'Halloran asked a question in the House as follows:—

BROKEN HILL WATER SUPPLY

In connection with the recent inquiry conducted by Mr Dridan, into the means of augmenting the water supply for Broken Hill, I understand that one suggestion was that water should be pumped from the River Murray. It has been put to me that if arrangements could be made with the New South Wales Government for joint participation in a scheme and the cost thereof, it might be possible to take water from near Morgan to Broken Hill and supply en route places like Terowie, which has not a water scheme, Peterborough, and other towns on the railway line between Peterborough and Broken Hill, where the Railways Department periodically experience considerable water supply difficulties. Will the Minister have the practicability of this suggestion investigated, perhaps by Mr Dridan, who is already making some inquiries at Broken Hill to see if the scheme is worthy of being adopted?

The Hon. M. McIntosh—The present proposal originated with the mining companies at Broken Hill and was supported by the New South Wales Premier, who sent the terms of reference, and the report will go back to New South Wales. If the terms of reference are wide enough to embrace the proposal incorporated in hon. member's suggestion I will ask the New South Wales Premier to have it considered and if not, whether he will have investigations made as to its practicability.

Following up this lead and in the hope of obtaining whole-hearted and substantial support from Peterborough, it was decided to 'start the ball rolling' in Peterborough and at the invitation of His Worship the Mayor, a meeting was held in the Mayor's Parlour on Monday afternoon to start a movement to have the Murray Water brought to Peterborough.

Those present were—His Worship the Mayor, the Town Clerk, Messrs M. R. O'Halloran, N. A. Foord, W. E. Sandow, H. C. Luck, H. E. Backhouse, C. V. Hoile, D. J. Wortley, and J. S. Bennett. Apologies came from Messrs P. J. Sullivan, W. E. Dowdy, L. Murphy and R. L. Partridge.

Mr Bowden opened the meeting and explained the purpose of the gathering, and Mr O'Halloran addressed those present and said he wanted a substantial backing from Peterborough to make possible a sewerage scheme in the town. To do this water, and good water in adequate supply, was required. In view of the present policy of decentralisation it was necessary that country residents should have some of the amenities of life enjoyed by dwellers in the cities and larger towns of the Commonwealth and, he thought, people in the more favoured parts of the State should be prepared to bear some of the cost of providing water for those in less fortunate places.

Several questions were answered and then Mr N. A. Foord moved that we form a strong committee to stand behind the proposition to improve the present water supply and have the Murray water brought to Peterborough. This was seconded by Mr C. V. Hoile.

Mr Foord then proposed that His Worship the Mayor (Mr R. J. Bowden) be chairman with Messrs D. J. Wortley and J. S. Bennett as secretaries, those present to form the committee with power to add. Seconded by Mr Backhouse and carried.

Mr Hoile moved "that in view of the possibility of Peterborough being sewered and the likelihood of the present water supply proving inadequate, also, in view of the bad quality of the water now supplied, we request the appropriate authority to give serious consideration to the problem of supplying an adequate quantity of good water by tapping the existing Morgan-Whyalla pipeline, or adopting the more recent suggestion that Terowie and Peterborough should be supplied with a connection with a proposal to take the Murray water to Broken Hill, and that this unanimous motion be forwarded to the Commissioner of Public Works forthwith." Seconded by Mr Wortley.

Mr Foord moved that a copy of the resolution be submitted to Mr A. E. Smith, Federal Member for Wakefield, seeking the Commonwealth Government's support of this project.

The meeting closed with votes of thanks to Mr O'Halloran, Mr Bowden and Mr House, which were carried with acclamation.

It was pointed out that to have a sewerage scheme in the town, and to attract other industries, good water is necessary and, for that reason, the support of the public is sought in placing our claims before the Government in this very necessary adjunct to our standard of living.

The potentialities opened up with an adequate supply of good water are enormous and we feel sure that every person will be vitally interested and give whole-hearted and keen support to the committee.

If you have an argument, for or against this project, it will be welcomed as the committee is anxious to have an expression of opinion from everybody.

Just think what GOOD WATER can do for OUR TOWN and put your weight behind this movement!

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More water restrictions were imposed in February 1945 as the level of the well had fallen. The restrictions were lifted in April.

The Public Standing Committee along with the district engineer of the E&WS department visited Peterborough in May 1947 with regard with providing the town with an improved and adequate water supply. It was remarked that the committee had visited in 1939, but the war had interrupted the review of evidence, and the committee had resumed its enquiries.

Mr. Christian said that the Committee had visited Peterborough and taken evidence in May, 1939 in connection with the revision of water supplies for various towns throughout the northern parts of the State. The war had interrupted the taking of evidence, and since the end of the war, the committee had resumed its enquiries and it was now practically certain that Laura would draw its water supplies from the Beetaloo reservoir and they were trying to arrange for Caltowie, Peterborough, Jamestown, Terowie and other intervening places to be supplied from the Morgan-Whyalla pipeline. The purpose tonight was to reopen the matter of bringing this service to Peterborough, and he urged all citizens to bear in mind that the scheme would be costly and consequently would mean a very sharp rise in water rates. The first witness called was Cr. P. J. Sullivan on behalf of the Corporation of the Town of Peterborough, who said there was not a great deal to add to the evidence previously given in 1939 but he wished to submit some further reasons for the need of providing water of a better quality than is now available.

When the present scheme was introduced in 1928 it was recognised as a great boom to the town generally but time has shown a limit to its usefulness, particularly regarding quality. The quantity is definitely limited and will be insufficient to meet developments likely to take place. Since the Water Scheme came to Peterborough gardens and lawns

were made possible where few had existed before but where the water had been extensively used the soil became very heavily mineralised and detracted greatly from its use for gardening purposes. Mr. Sullivan then submitted that good quality water would remove this disability. Apart from that, the present water had a bad effect on galvanised water pipes and iron fences which came in contact with the water in the soil. Pathways became powdery and the only material other than concrete or bitumen that withstood the chemical action of the water is a very hard quartzite.

Mr. James Casey speaking for the Progress Association, said the water was unsuitable for all requirements. The Association had discussed the merits of the Morgan-Whyalla pipeline and would like to see the scheme come to Peterborough. He thought the townspeople would be prepared to accept higher charges for good water and 2/6 a 1,000 gallons seemed a reasonable figure. He said the majority of the townspeople did not like the sanitary pan system and should a sewerage scheme be introduced there probably would be some arguments before it was finally accepted. However, it was necessary.

Mr. G. H. Koch said although he was interested in the majority of the land bordering the proposed route, he would not oppose it if it meant improving the water supply for Peterborough.

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A plan to provide water from the Morgan-Whyalla pipe line to Jamestown, Caltowie and country to the west was approved on Monday 12th January 1948. This plan also included the future inclusion of Peterborough and Terowie when an extension could be considered.

Tenders were called for the construction of a million-gallon water storage tank for Peterborough and the SA Minister of Works approved the necessary expenditure to investigate a sewerage scheme.

Due to the shortage of manpower and materials there was no response to the tender. The chief storekeeper had placed an order for sufficient steel to be imported but as an import licence had not been granted, it was not certain that the government could obtain the needed material.

At a dinner at Casey's hotel held by the Mayor Mr E.H. Fowler on Monday 26th September 1949, the local representative Mr M.R. O'Halloran MP, spoke about the town being connected to the Murray River water scheme. The construction of the new million-gallon storage tank was due to start, and the steel reinforcing rods had arrived.

so dear. Speaking about the projected water supply improvement for Peterborough, Mr. O'Halloran said the day was coming when Murray water would be available to Peterborough residents as they turned on their taps. Already the steel reinforcing rods to construct the million gallon storage tank were on hand and we could expect an early start on the construction. As everybody was aware, the public works programme had been retarded by the all-out war effort but the main being laid to Jamestown from Spalding would be of sufficient size to supply Peterborough when the necessary material became available. A sewerage scheme was of necessity linked up with water. Surveys were to be conducted soon and the Public Works Standing Committee had definitely decided that Peterborough would be included in those country towns to be provided with sewerage schemes.

The future of Peterborough will be secure from a Railway standpoint and the latest proposal to broaden to standard guage from Broken Hill to Port Pirie, and Peterborough to Alice Springs sections, of the railway should be carried out in a few years and this would mean that all the cross-continental traffic would go direct to Sydney through Peterborough. He expected that the line from Terowie to Peterborough would be standard guage rather than broad. Mr. O'Halloran expects that all Trust Homes recently erected in Peterborough would be occupied by Christmas and more were to be built some of which would be prefabricated. He intended pressing strongly for more Housing Trust Homes at Peterborough and the Minister in charge of this work had assured him that were a tractor available, the Trust would immediately begin construction of more homes in our town.

*Times and Northern Advertiser
Friday 30 September 1949*

A public meeting on Friday 4th December 1953 saw over 500 people resolve a resolution to urge the government to extend the water main being laid at Jamestown to Peterborough. The water pressure in the town had been so low that water was only available for a limited time each day. The hospital was without water of half the day, and the fire hazard was high due to the low pressure of water. The railway dam at Gumbowie was empty and water carting for the railways at Terowie was costing the government a fortune. This would be reduced if water was piped to Peterborough. The bore water the town relied on was so mineralised that it crumbled the stone of buildings. The local board of health had condemned the swimming pool, and it had to be disposed of.

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Several new industries were wanting to be established in the town but cannot do so because of the quality and quantity of the water available.

Finally in December 1954, the government approved a proposal to extend a branch-main from the Morgan to Whyalla pipeline to provided Peterborough with a permanent water supply.

The Public Works Standing Committee took evidence in April 1955, and the town was finally connected with the Murray River - Morgan to Whyalla pipeline in January 1958.



*Water Storage Tanks – Government Road
Front: half-million-gallon tank built in 1927, back: million-gallon tank built in 1950
Photo Janet Fielding*

